conversation with Bawds that had started, very unsteadily, at the back of the team bus on the way to Potchefstroom for a warm-up match against South Africa A, a little less than a year earlier.

I can say this now, because he is a trusted adviser who has my complete respect, but on that day he looked like a competition winner. Slightly overweight, glasses, a geek sent from central casting. No one had seen him before yet there he was, trying to negotiate the invisible minefield of seating arrangements on the bus. Everyone, coaches and players, has their own spot.

Fortunately, we had taken only twelve players; I was twelfth man because of a back twinge and was at the back of the bus, to the left. Since Jimmy and Swanny were off duty, there was space to the right of me for the hour-long journey. Bawds plonked himself down and, since I don't really listen to music on headphones, I steeled myself for polite conversation.

He was nervous, a little too eager, as he immediately outlined his thoughts on the relevance of his trade. To be honest, I was standoffish. I knew the advantages of training the brain but had never really thrown myself into it. I preferred the more literal benefits of a biceps curl, bench press or squat in the gym.

The theory of sports psychology was introduced in Under-19 training camps, but I had still to be convinced of its practical application. That wasn't a reflection on Bawds's professionalism; scepticism is invariably deep rooted in sport. Some of the rah-rah, happy-clappy slogans passed off as leadership maxims in the corporate world would, frankly, be laughed out of an international dressing room.

I played the role of slightly sour old pro. We were about to pull up to the ground when I presented the psychologist with a challenge: 'I want to have more confidence. I want to feel able to back myself more. When you've watched me work, come back with something that is relevant to me, not token bullshit.' With hindsight, it was probably no surprise he confided to friends: 'Crikey. He's going to be hard work.'

I probably hid my self-doubt better than most. The guy who is struggling, deep in the bush, usually gives himself away. He has an almost hollow-eyed expression, the vacant stare of someone who is searching, worrying, losing trust in himself. He doesn't consciously detach himself from the group, but there is a subtle difference in outlook and approach.